

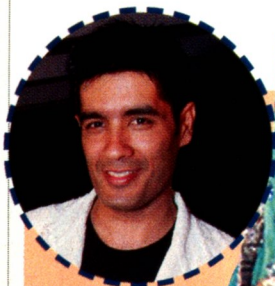
LIST



SURILY GOEL Having worked with Preity Zinta (left, in pink) in *Salaam Namaste*, she now does most of her Indian clothes for functions.

woman can start off nationwide trends by planning the minutiae of celebrity clotheshorses and tabloid fixtures such as Lindsay Lohan and Nicole Richie, but increasingly, no one is immune to the need to dress up. Ask Vidya Balan, who has learnt the hard way that "you have to look glamorous even if you have lost your memory"—a reference to the loose kurtis and skirts she wore in Nikhil Advani's *Salaam-e-Ishq*. Her onscreen skirmishes with Manish Malhotra, who designed her smartened-up look in *Heyy Babyy* have been matched by tabloid fashion police attacking her new hair (short) and her new hemline (shorter), both courtesy Shabina Khan, the designer of her forthcoming Aziz Mirza film, *Lucky Charm*.

Or take Madhuri Dixit, whose promotional appearances for *Aaja Nachle* were as meticulously designed-for as her screen look. So whether it was an appearance on *Nach Baliye*, where she wore an Anarkali kurta, or a Delhi press conference, where, in deference to the colder weather, she wore a black top, jeans and combi-



MANISH MALHOTRA The Bollywood woman's favourite designer. Styled Madhuri Dixit (right) for her promotional appearances for *Aaja Nachle*.

nation pashmina stole, Malhotra had every look accounted for. Or Aishwarya Rai, who picked up a Gauri and Nainika Karan dress (and a lot more) for a recent Derby appearance in Mumbai for the watch brand Longines, after calling the designers across to her hotel on a recent visit to Delhi.

The Delhi-based sisters are Bollywood's latest discoveries, their classic Hollywood gowns adorning Deepika Padukone at a New York black tie event as well as Lara Dutta for an appearance on Star TV's *Koffee with Karan*. But sometimes, short notices don't always yield quick results. Preity Zinta, a great buyer of foreign labels with the largest collection of shoes and bags in Bollywood, asked them for a dress two days before the *Vogue* launch. They didn't have her measurements offhand, and she went with a baby pink dress that Surily Goel, who styled her in *Salaam Namaste* and *Jaan-e-Mann*, made for her.

It's a cut-throat business, but no one can afford to feel bad. Rani Mukherji, for instance, asked Malhotra to design a sari for her for the *Saawariya* premiere, but eventually chose a kurta and straight pants from the film's designer Anuradha Vakil. That night was quite busy for Malhotra—he designed a quilted jacquard jacket for Priyanka Chopra (and asked her to team it with skinny jeans), a black net saree for Kareena Kapoor and an Anarkali kurta for Urmila Matondkar. Oh, and he couldn't go to London, but designed Padukone's lehnga choli for *Om Shanti Om*'s premiere the next day.

Yet there are more fashion failures than there are svelte successes. As director Karan Johar says, "For the women, the saree is a safe bet. Those Valentino gowns look great on tall women with tiny waists. In Hollywood, women have a lot of work done to their

